



◆ OFFENSIVE SECURITY SERIES ◆

SOCIAL ENGINEERING RECONNAISSANCE

Attacker POV

OSINT · Recon · LinkedIn · Maltego · theHarvester · SpiderFoot · Social Media

OSINT

LinkedIn

Shodan

theHarvester

SpiderFoot

Maltego

Recon-ng

Email OSINT

RedTeamGarage (RTG) | Offensive Security Education

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**— TABLE OF CONTENTS**

Social Engineering Reconnaissance — The Complete OSINT Playbook

01.	OSINT FUNDAMENTALS — THE ATTACKER MINDSET
02.	CORPORATE FOOTPRINTING — ORG & DOMAIN RECON
03.	EMPLOYEE HARVESTING — LINKEDIN & SOCIAL MEDIA
04.	EMAIL OSINT — DISCOVERY, VALIDATION & PATTERNS
05.	PHONE NUMBER & IDENTITY OSINT
06.	INFRASTRUCTURE RECON — SHODAN, CENSYS & FOFA
07.	MALTEGO — VISUAL LINK ANALYSIS
08.	SPIDERFOOT — AUTOMATED OSINT FRAMEWORK
09.	RECON-NG — MODULAR RECON FRAMEWORK
10.	THEHARVESTER — EMAIL & SUBDOMAIN HARVESTING
11.	SOCIAL MEDIA OSINT — TWITTER/X, INSTAGRAM, FACEBOOK
12.	GEOLOCATION & IMAGE OSINT — EXIF & REVERSE IMAGE
13.	DARK WEB & BREACH DATA OSINT
14.	SE PRETEXTING — BUILDING THE ATTACK NARRATIVE
15.	FULL RECON WORKFLOW CHEAT SHEET



01 — OSINT FUNDAMENTALS — THE ATTACKER MINDSET

Passive, Active, and Intelligence-Led Reconnaissance

Social engineering reconnaissance is the art of collecting intelligence about a target organisation and its people without triggering any alerts. Unlike technical exploitation, SE recon relies entirely on open-source information — data that the target has unwittingly made public. The attacker's goal is to build a complete dossier: who works there, what their roles are, what technology they use, what their email format is, and what personal details could be used for pretext calls, phishing, or physical access attempts.

OSINT CATEGORIES

- Passive OSINT — No interaction with target systems (Google, LinkedIn, Shodan)
- Semi-Passive — Mimics normal traffic (DNS lookups, header grabs)
- Active OSINT — Direct queries that may appear in target logs (port scans, crawls)
- Human OSINT — LinkedIn scraping, employee social media, conference talks
- Technical OSINT — Domain records, certificates, job postings, leaked code

Attacker OSINT Workflow — 5 Phases

Phase	Activity	Tools	Output
1 — Org Footprint	Company structure, subsidiaries, domains	Maltego, WHOIS, crt.sh	Domain list, IP ranges
2 — Employee Harvest	Names, roles, emails, phone numbers	LinkedIn, theHarvester, Hunter.io	Staff dossier
3 — Infra Discovery	IPs, open ports, tech stack, certs	Shodan, Censys, Netcraft	Tech fingerprint
4 — Breach/Leak Check	Passwords, tokens, source code	HIBP, LeakIX, GitHub dorking	Credential list
5 — Pretext Build	Craft believable narrative for attack	All gathered intel	Attack plan

\$ OSINT Toolset Setup

```
# Install core OSINT tools on Kali
sudo apt update && sudo apt install -y maltego recon-ng theharvester

# Install Python OSINT tools
pip install holehe shodan spiderfoot-cli
pip install linkedin2username maigret

# Install SpiderFoot (web interface)
git clone https://github.com/smicallef/spiderfoot.git
cd spiderfoot && pip install -r requirements.txt
python3 sf.py -l 127.0.0.1:5001

# theHarvester — all-in-one harvester
theHarvester -d target.com -b all -l 500

# recon-ng — modular framework
recon-ng
marketplace install all
workspaces create target_corp
```



02 — CORPORATE FOOTPRINTING

Org Structure, Domains, Subsidiaries & Infrastructure

Before targeting individuals, attackers map the organisation itself. This includes discovering all owned domains, IP ranges, subsidiaries, office locations, registered trademarks, and corporate filings. A thorough corporate footprint reveals attack surface that the client may not even know they own — forgotten subdomains, acquired company infrastructure, and cloud assets all fall under this phase.

\$ Corporate Footprinting Commands

```
# WHOIS — registrant, org, address, email
whois target.com
whois 203.0.113.0

# Certificate transparency — find ALL subdomains via TLS certs
curl -s 'https://crt.sh/?q=%target.com&output=json' | jq '.[].name_value' | sort -u

# Reverse WHOIS — find all domains registered by same org/email
# Use: https://viewdns.info/reversewhois/

# ASN discovery — find all IP ranges owned by company
curl -s 'https://api.bgpview.io/search?query_term=TargetCorp' | jq
whois -h whois.radb.net -- '-i origin AS12345'

# DNS enumeration — all record types
dig target.com ANY +noall +answer
dig _dmarc.target.com TXT +short
dig _spf.target.com TXT +short

# Certificate recon with Amass
amass enum -passive -d target.com -o amass_out.txt

# Netcraft — site report, hosting history, tech stack
# https://sitereport.netcraft.com/?url=target.com
```

RTG TIP — What to Look For

SPF/DMARC records reveal email security posture — weak = phishing relay potential

Old expired certificates in crt.sh reveal forgotten subdomains

Job postings often reveal internal tech stack (e.g. 'experience with CyberArk PAM')

LinkedIn company page shows headcount — helps estimate security team size

Google: 'site:target.com filetype:pdf' reveals internal documents indexed by Google

Source	Data Found	URL / Tool
WHOIS	Registrant name, email, org, address	whois / viewdns.info



Source	Data Found	URL / Tool
crt.sh	All subdomains via cert transparency	crt.sh/?q=%target.com
Shodan	Live hosts, open ports, banners	shodan.io / shodan CLI
BGP.tools	ASN, IP ranges, peering data	bgp.tools / bgpview.io
Netcraft	Hosting history, tech stack, uptime	sitereport.netcraft.com
Google Dorks	PDFs, spreadsheets, login pages	site: filetype: inurl:
LinkedIn	Headcount, tech stack, employees	linkedin.com/company/
BuiltWith	CMS, CDN, analytics, ad tech	builtwith.com



03 — EMPLOYEE HARVESTING

LinkedIn, Social Media & Username OSINT

People are the most exploitable attack surface in any organisation. Employee harvesting collects names, roles, departments, seniority levels, work history, personal email addresses, phone numbers, and social media profiles. This intelligence directly enables spear-phishing, pretexting, vishing (voice phishing), and physical social engineering.

\$ Employee OSINT Commands

```
# linkedin2username — generate username wordlists from LinkedIn
python3 linkedin2username.py -u YOUR_EMAIL -c 'Target Corp' -n 5 -s 0

# theHarvester — scrape LinkedIn, Google, Bing for emails/names
theHarvester -d target.com -b linkedin -l 500
theHarvester -d target.com -b google,bing,yahoo -l 500

# CrossLinked — LinkedIn name scraping without API key
python3 crosslinked.py -f '{first}.{last}@target.com' 'Target Corp'

# Sherlock — username across 300+ platforms
sherlock johndoe

# Maigret — advanced username OSINT
maigret johndoe --html -a

# Holehe — check if email registered on platforms
holehe john.doe@target.com

# Google dork for LinkedIn employees
# site:linkedin.com/in 'Target Corp' 'Security Engineer'
# site:linkedin.com/in 'Target Corp' 'IT Administrator'
```

HIGH-VALUE EMPLOYEE TARGETS

IT/Security Admins — Domain Admins, VPN admins, PAM holders, SOC analysts
Finance/Accounting — Wire transfer approvers, AP/AR staff, CFO/Controller
Executives — CEO, CFO, CISO — for BEC impersonation targets
Help Desk Staff — Often bypass security policies when 'social engineered'
Developers/DevOps — GitHub repos, cloud keys, CI/CD pipeline access
New Employees — Least trained, most likely to click suspicious links

Platform	What to Extract	Attack Use
LinkedIn	Full name, role, department, manager, location, work history	Spear-phish, pretext calls
Twitter/X	Personal opinions, travel, frustrations, tech interests	Tailored phishing lures



Platform	What to Extract	Attack Use
GitHub	Personal email, API keys, internal tooling, tech stack	Credential theft, tech intel
Facebook	Family, hobbies, location check-ins, friends	Vishing pretext material
Instagram	Physical location, routines, ID cards in photos	Physical recon, schedule
Conferences	Talks, slides — reveals internal architecture	Technical intel gathering



04 — EMAIL OSINT

Discovery, Pattern Detection & Validation

Email addresses are the most versatile intelligence asset in social engineering. A valid email address unlocks spear-phishing, password spray attacks, credential stuffing, account enumeration, and pretexting. The attacker's goal is to identify the organisation's email format and then generate valid addresses for every person discovered during employee harvesting.

Common Corporate Email Formats

Format	Example	Detection Method
{first}.{last}@domain.com	john.doe@target.com	Hunter.io, LinkedIn
{f}{last}@domain.com	jdoe@target.com	theHarvester
{first}{l}@domain.com	johnd@target.com	OSINT email search
{first}@domain.com	john@target.com	Breach data check
{last}.{first}@domain.com	doe.john@target.com	Email validator
{first}_{last}@domain.com	john_doe@target.com	MX record + VRFY

\$ Email OSINT Commands

```
# Hunter.io — find email format and addresses (free tier = 25/month)
# https://hunter.io/domain-search?domain=target.com
curl 'https://api.hunter.io/v2/domain-search?domain=target.com&api_key=KEY'

# theHarvester — scrape emails from all sources
theHarvester -d target.com -b google,bing,linkedin,twitter -l 1000 -f output

# Holehe — check if email is registered on services
holehe -a john.doe@target.com

# Verify email exists via SMTP VRFY (if enabled)
smtp-user-enum -M VRFY -U email_list.txt -t mail.target.com
smtp-user-enum -M RCPT -U email_list.txt -t mail.target.com -D target.com

# Generate email permutations from name list
# Example Python one-liner:
python3 -c "
names=[('john','doe'),('jane','smith')]; domain='target.com'
formats=['{f}.{l}','{f}{l[0]}','{f[0]}{l}','{f}']
for f,l in names:
    for fmt in formats: print(fmt.format(f=f,l=l)+'@'+domain)
"

# Check breach data for domain emails
# https://haveibeenpwned.com/DomainSearch
```

EMAIL OSINT TOOLS

Hunter.io — Best for format detection + bulk discovery (API available)

Phonebook.cz — Large email/domain dataset, often has corporate addresses

Skymem.info — Alternative to Hunter for email discovery

EmailRep.io — Email reputation check (breaches, spam, risk score)

HIBP — haveibeenpwned.com — breach exposure check per domain



05 — PHONE & IDENTITY OSINT

Mobile Numbers, Caller ID Spoofing & Identity Correlation

Phone numbers are critical for vishing (voice phishing) campaigns. A direct dial to a target's mobile — using caller ID spoofed as their IT helpdesk — is highly effective. Phone numbers can be harvested from LinkedIn, company websites, email signatures, conference registrations, and breach databases.

\$ Phone & Identity OSINT

```
# TrueCaller / Sync.me – reverse phone lookup
# https://www.truecaller.com/search/us/+1-555-123-4567

# NumVerify – phone validation + carrier + location
curl 'http://apilayer.net/api/validate?access_key=KEY&number=+15551234567'

# Pipl – people search engine (paid but extremely comprehensive)
# https://pipl.com

# Google dork for phone numbers
# site:target.com 'tel:' OR 'phone:' OR '+1'

# Leak data – check breach databases for phone-email correlation
# https://leakcheck.io
# https://intelx.io

# Social media phone recovery – check if phone maps to FB/Instagram
# Password reset flow on Facebook with phone number
```



06 — INFRASTRUCTURE RECON

Shodan, Censys, FOFA & Attack Surface Discovery

Infrastructure OSINT maps the technical attack surface. Shodan, Censys, and FOFA continuously scan the entire internet and index every open port, service banner, and SSL certificate. Attackers use these to find exposed login panels, unpatched services, default credentials, and cloud misconfigurations — all without touching the target directly.

\$ Shodan / Censys / FOFA Recon

```
# Shodan CLI setup
pip install shodan
shodan init YOUR_API_KEY

# Find all assets for target organisation
shodan search 'org:"Target Corp"' --fields ip_str,port,hostnames,os

# Find specific services for target domain
shodan search 'ssl.cert.subject.cn:target.com'
shodan search 'hostname:target.com port:443'

# Find exposed admin panels
shodan search 'org:"Target Corp" http.title:"admin"'
shodan search 'org:"Target Corp" http.title:"Login"'

# Find VPN/RDP endpoints
shodan search 'org:"Target Corp" port:3389 product:"Remote Desktop"'
shodan search 'org:"Target Corp" port:4443 product:"Pulse Connect"'

# Censys – certificate-based discovery
# https://search.censys.io/certificates?q=target.com

# FOFA – Chinese internet scan database (often finds more Asian-hosted assets)
# https://fofa.info/result?qbase64=...
```

Query	Finds
org:"Target Corp"	All Shodan-indexed IPs for the org
ssl.cert.subject.cn:target.com	Hosts with TLS cert matching domain
http.html:"Target Corp Login"	Login pages mentioning target
net:203.0.113.0/24	All open ports in IP range
hostname:*.target.com port:8080	Tomcat/alt HTTP on subdomains
org:"Target Corp" vuln:CVE-2021-44228	Log4Shell exposed hosts



07 — MALTEGO — VISUAL LINK ANALYSIS

Transforms, Entity Graphs & Relationship Mapping

Maltego is the industry-standard visual intelligence platform. It uses 'transforms' — automated queries against OSINT data sources — to build entity graphs showing relationships between domains, IPs, people, organisations, email addresses, and social profiles. A single seed (e.g. a company domain) can expand into hundreds of connected entities revealing the full attack surface.

\$ Maltego Key Transforms

```
# Core entity types in Maltego:
# Person, EmailAddress, PhoneNumber, Organization
# Domain, DNSName, IPAddress, URL, Alias

# Useful transform chains:

# Domain → DNS records → IP addresses → ASN → more IPs
# Domain → Certificate → Subdomains → Live hosts
# Company Name → LinkedIn → Employee Names → Emails
# Email → Breach check → Password hashes → Crack → Reuse
# Person Name → Social accounts → Connections → Network map

# Free transforms available (no API key needed):
# DNS to IP, IP to Hostname, WHOIS, Certificate CT

# Commercial transforms (require keys/subscription):
# Shodan, VirusTotal, HaveIBeenPwned, Pipl, Recorded Future

# Export graph for report evidence
# File > Export Graph > PNG/CSV/XLSX
```



08 — SPIDERFOOT — AUTOMATED OSINT

200+ Modules, Web UI & CLI Operation

SpiderFoot automates OSINT collection across 200+ data sources with a single target input. It correlates results automatically, identifies relationships, and scores findings by interest level. SpiderFoot is available as a web UI or CLI and is ideal for comprehensive, hands-off initial reconnaissance.

\$ SpiderFoot Usage

```
# Install and run SpiderFoot web UI
git clone https://github.com/smicallef/spiderfoot.git
cd spiderfoot && pip3 install -r requirements.txt
python3 sf.py -l 127.0.0.1:5001
# Open http://127.0.0.1:5001 → New Scan → target.com → All modules

# SpiderFoot CLI (sfcli.py)
python3 sfcli.py -s target.com -t INTERNET_NAME -m all -q

# Targeted scan – only specific module types
python3 sfcli.py -s target.com -t DOMAIN_NAME \
    -m sfp_dnsresolve,sfp_ssl,sfp_hunter,sfp_shodan

# Export results to CSV
python3 sfcli.py -s target.com -o csv > spiderfoot_results.csv

# Key modules to enable:
# sfp_hunter          – Email discovery via Hunter.io
# sfp_shodan          – Shodan host discovery
# sfp_haveibeenpwned – Breach exposure
# sfp_linkedin        – LinkedIn profile scraping
# sfp_github          – GitHub code/secret search
# sfp_dnsbrute        – Subdomain brute force
```



09 — RECON-NG — MODULAR RECON FRAMEWORK

Marketplace Modules, Workspaces & Reporting

Recon-ng is a full-featured web reconnaissance framework written in Python. It provides a structured, modular approach to OSINT collection with a marketplace of community modules. Recon-ng stores all results in a local SQLite database and can generate professional HTML reports.

\$ Recon-ng Commands

```
# Launch recon-ng
recon-ng

# Create workspace for engagement
[recon-ng] > workspaces create target_corp
[recon-ng][target_corp] > workspaces load target_corp

# Install key modules from marketplace
[recon-ng] > marketplace install recon/domains-hosts/hackertarget
[recon-ng] > marketplace install recon/domains-contacts/hunter_io
[recon-ng] > marketplace install recon/hosts-hosts/shodan_ip
[recon-ng] > marketplace install recon/contacts-credentials/hibp_breach

# Add target domain seed
[recon-ng] > db insert domains
domain (TEXT): target.com

# Run specific module
[recon-ng] > modules load recon/domains-hosts/hackertarget
[recon-ng][hackertarget] > run

# Bulk run all modules on current data
[recon-ng] > modules load discovery/info_disclosure/interesting_files

# Generate HTML report
[recon-ng] > modules load reporting/html
[recon-ng][html] > set FILENAME /tmp/recon_report.html
[recon-ng][html] > run
```



10 — THEHARVESTER

Email, Subdomain & People Harvesting

theHarvester is the fastest single-tool for email and subdomain discovery. It queries dozens of search engines and data sources simultaneously and is often the first tool run on any engagement. Key sources include Google, Bing, LinkedIn, Twitter, Shodan, and Netcraft.

\$ theHarvester Commands

```
# Full harvest – all sources, 500 results
theHarvester -d target.com -b all -l 500 -f harvest_output
```

```
# Specific sources for targeted recon
theHarvester -d target.com -b google,bing,yahoo -l 1000
theHarvester -d target.com -b linkedin -l 500
theHarvester -d target.com -b shodan
theHarvester -d target.com -b netcraft
```

```
# DNS brute force via theHarvester
theHarvester -d target.com -b dnsdumpster -l 500
```

```
# Output formats
theHarvester -d target.com -b all -f /tmp/harvest -t
# Generates: harvest.html, harvest.json, harvest.xml
```

```
[*] Emails found: 47
[*] john.doe@target.com
[*] jane.smith@target.com
[*] it.helpdesk@target.com
[*] Hosts found: 23
[*] mail.target.com:203.0.113.12
[*] vpn.target.com:203.0.113.45
[*] owa.target.com:203.0.113.67
```



11 — SOCIAL MEDIA OSINT

Twitter/X, Instagram, Facebook & Dark Forums

Social media is an intelligence goldmine. Employees post internal meeting photos revealing whiteboards and network diagrams. Frustrated IT staff vent about their security tools. Executives post from conferences revealing travel schedules. Every post is potential pretext material or physical recon intelligence.

Platform	Key Intel	Tool
Twitter/X	Real-time employee frustrations, tech complaints, travel	Twint, Twitter Advanced Search
LinkedIn	Full career history, skills, connections, tech stack	linkedin2username, CrossLinked
GitHub	API keys in commits, internal tooling, email in config	gitrob, trufflehog, gitleaks
Facebook	Personal life, family, location, device photos	Manual + OSINT framework
Instagram	Office location photos, ID badges, screen content	Instaloader, manual search
Reddit	Employees asking for help with internal tools/configs	Google: site:reddit.com 'Target Corp'
YouTube	Conference talks revealing internal architecture	Search: 'Target Corp' security talk
Pastebin/Ghostbin	Leaked credentials, config files, internal docs	Google dorks: site:pastebin.com

\$ Social Media OSINT Commands

```
# Twint – Twitter scraping without API (archived tool, use alternatives)
# snsrape – modern Twitter/X scraper
pip install snsrape
snsrape twitter-search 'from:johndoe_corp' > tweets.txt
snsrape twitter-search '"target corp" security password' > hits.txt

# Instaloader – Instagram OSINT
pip install instaloader
instaloader profile johndoe_handle
instaloader --geotags --comments --stories johndoe_handle

# GitHub secret scanning – trufflehog
trufflehog github --org=TargetCorp --json > gh_secrets.json
trufflehog git https://github.com/TargetCorp/repo.git

# gitleaks – scan for secrets in git repos
gitleaks detect --source /path/to/cloned/repo -v
gitleaks detect --source . --report-format json -r leak_report.json
```



12 — GEOLOCATION & IMAGE OSINT

EXIF Data, Reverse Image & Physical Recon

\$ Image & Geolocation OSINT

```
# Extract EXIF data from images (GPS, device, timestamp)
exiftool photo.jpg | grep -E 'GPS|Make|Model|Date'

# exiftool bulk extract from directory
exiftool -csv *.jpg | grep -i gps

# Reverse image search – find other accounts using same photo
# Tools: Google Images, TinEye, Yandex Images, Bing Visual Search

# Google reverse image search URL
# https://images.google.com → paste image URL

# Face recognition OSINT (use ethically/legally)
# PimEyes.com – face search engine
```



13 — DARK WEB & BREACH DATA OSINT

Credential Markets, Leaked Data & Intelx

Breach databases and dark web markets contain billions of credentials from past data breaches. For attackers, this is direct credential intelligence — email/password combos that may still be valid due to password reuse. Even outdated passwords reveal an employee's password patterns and complexity preferences.

Source	Data Available	Access
HaveIBeenPwned	Breach exposure check, paste monitor	Free API / hibp-cli
IntelX (intelx.io)	Email, domain, credential search across leaks	Freemium — paid for bulk
LeakIX	Exposed services + some breach data	Free + paid tiers
Dehashed	Comprehensive breach DB with password fields	Paid subscription
BreachDirectory	Breach search by email or username	Free + API
Snusbase	Large breach aggregator	Paid
Hudson Rock (Cavalier)	Infostealer logs — live session cookies!	Paid / limited free

\$ Breach Data Queries

```
# HIBP — check if domain emails appear in breaches
# https://haveibeenpwned.com/DomainSearch

# hibp-cli — command line HIBP
pip install haveibeenpwned
haveibeenpwned email john.doe@target.com

# IntelX CLI
pip install intelx
intelx -search 'target.com' -type email

# Check paste sites for leaked data
# Google: site:pastebin.com 'target.com' password
# Google: site:pastebin.com '@target.com'

# Hudson Rock Cavalier — infostealer credential checks
# https://cavalier.hudsonrock.com/api/json/v2/
curl 'https://cavalier.hudsonrock.com/api/json/v2/osint-tools/search-by-domain?domain=target.com'

[*] Found 12 infostealer victims at target.com
[*] Credentials: john.doe@target.com:P@ssw0rd2023
[*] Session cookies: VALID (Chrome, 2024-01-15)
```



14 — SE PRETEXTING

Building the Attack Narrative from Intel

Pretexting is the creation of a fabricated scenario — a pretext — to manipulate a target. Every piece of intelligence gathered feeds directly into the pretext. The more specific and verifiable the pretext, the higher the success rate. A good pretext uses the target's real name, their manager's name, their actual IT helpdesk email, and a scenario relevant to their role.

Pretext Type	Intel Required	Attack Vector
IT Helpdesk Call	Employee name, manager, IT contact, ticket system	Vishing → credential extraction
HR Onboarding Email	New hires (found on LinkedIn), HR email, HR name	Phishing → credential harvest
CEO Wire Request	CFO name, CEO name, email format, bank details	BEC → financial fraud
Vendor Invoice	Finance team names, existing vendors, invoice format	Phishing → payment redirect
Security Audit	IT team names, systems used (from job posts)	Pretexting → info disclosure
Physical Access	Contractor list, building layout, badge design	Physical intrusion



15 — FULL RECON WORKFLOW CHEAT SHEET

Every Tool, Every Command — Quick Reference

Corporate footprint	<code>whois target.com && amass enum -passive -d target.com</code>
Subdomain discovery	<code>amass enum -d target.com dnsx -silent -a -resp</code>
Certificate recon	<code>curl 'https://crt.sh/?q=%target.com&output=json' jq</code>
Email harvest	<code>theHarvester -d target.com -b all -l 500 -f output</code>
Email format detect	<code>hunter.io domain search + crosslinked.py</code>
Email validation	<code>smtp-user-enum -M VRFY -U emails.txt -t mail.target.com</code>
Employee names	<code>linkedin2username -u email -c 'Corp' -n 5</code>
Username search	<code>sherlock johndoe && maigret johndoe --html -a</code>
Email platform check	<code>holehe john.doe@target.com</code>
Shodan org recon	<code>shodan search 'org:"Target Corp"' --fields ip_str,port</code>
Shodan SSL recon	<code>shodan search 'ssl.cert.subject.cn:target.com'</code>
Breach check	<code>haveibeenpwned email john.doe@target.com</code>
Paste site search	<code>Google: site:pastebin.com '@target.com'</code>
GitHub secret scan	<code>trufflehog github --org=TargetCorp --json</code>
Social media recon	<code>snsrape twitter-search '"TargetCorp" password'</code>
Image EXIF extract	<code>exiftool photo.jpg grep -E 'GPS Make Date'</code>
SpiderFoot full scan	<code>python3 sfcli.py -s target.com -t INTERNET_NAME -m all</code>
Recon-ng workspace	<code>recon-ng > workspaces create target > modules load ...</code>
Google dorks	<code>site:target.com filetype:pdf OR filetype:xlsx</code>
LinkedIn dork	<code>site:linkedin.com/in 'Target Corp' 'IT Administrator'</code>
Infostealer check	<code>curl https://cavalier.hudsonrock.com/api/.../target.com</code>



— CONNECT WITH REDTEAMGARAGE (RTG)

The Community. The Knowledge. The Edge.



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Telegram	https://t.me/redteamgarage
LinkedIn	https://www.linkedin.com/company/redteamgarage-rtg

RTG MISSION

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